

Introducing Open VBX



OpenVBX, an open source business phone platform launched by Twilio under the Mozilla Public License, provides an install-free solution that can be hosted on your Web server or on a cloud provider like Amazon EC2, and then used to build call and SMS flows.

If you're seeking to build an application that can work across voice, SMS and IM, there are plenty of options available. What earlier used to be a complex and costly integration can now be created and launched using simple Web wizards and programming, thanks to cloud platforms like OpenVBX. These managed service platforms allow you to build very powerful voice and text applications right into your browser.

OpenVBX is a virtual MySQL and PHP-based PBX, which can be downloaded from Twilio's website or from GitHub.

Call or SMS flows themselves are driven by widgets that you may drag-and-drop. Some of the possibilities are:

- Getting a local or toll-free phone number, for users to call.
- Routing calls to the menu, individuals, teams and voice-mails.
- Letting the first individual from a team take the phone call.
- Building conference lines and menus.
- Transcribing voice mails.

Let's look at how to install OpenVBX, build a sample application, and then test it.

Install OpenVBX

- Get the zip file and deploy it on your Web server.
- Access the root page and walk through the installer. You will need a MySQL database.
- Register for a free Twilio account.

Sample application

This requires a basic set-up and then workflow building. Let's look at a simple call workflow.

- Log in to OpenVBX with your Twilio account.
- Set up a device, by giving it a device name and number. You can choose to receive an SMS notification on the device.
- Set up voice-mail via text-to-speech, an MP3, or recording using a phone.
- Create a new call flow using the wizard. When a call begins, choose to read a greeting from text. After the prompt, provide a menu with Options 1 and 2. For Option 1, play a song; for Option 2, play voice mail for a user; for Option 3, send an SMS back to the caller, and hang up.
- Configure other options (e.g., play the menu only once).
- Save the flow.

You don't need to be a programmer to create such a workflow, and you will be amazed at the simplicity with which you can let your imagination loose.

Test the sample application

- Get a sandbox number and PIN from Twilio, and configure it with this flow in the OpenVBX portal. (For privacy reasons, my sandbox PIN number is not shared here. Get yours after registering for a free testing account.)
- Call this number with the PIN.
- Observe the above workflow playing for you.
- Wonder at how easy this was, with zero programming so far!

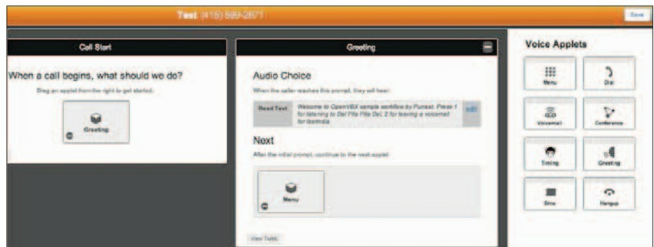


Figure 1: Call Flow1